humans did learn how to build more benevolent industrial societies. Imperial conquests, world wars, genocides and totalitarian regimes were woeful experiments that taught humans how *not* to do it. By the end of the twentieth century, some might argue, humanity got it more or less right.

Yet even so the message to the twenty-first century is bleak. If it took humanity so many terrible lessons to learn how to manage steam power and telegraphs, what would it cost to learn to manage bioengineering and AI? Do we need to go through another cycle of global empires, totalitarian regimes and world wars in order to figure out how to use them benevolently? The technologies of the twenty-first century are far more powerful – and potentially far more destructive – than those of the twentieth century. We therefore have less room for error. In the twentieth century, we can say that humanity got a C-minus in the lesson on using industrial technology. Just enough to pass. In the twenty-first century, the bar is set much higher. We must do better this time.

THE DEMOCRATIC WAY

By the end of the twentieth century, it had become clear that imperialism, totalitarianism and militarism were not the ideal way to build industrial societies. Despite all its flaws, liberal democracy offered a better way. The great advantage of liberal democracy is that it possesses strong self-correcting mechanisms, which limit the excesses of fanaticism and preserve the ability to recognise our errors and try different courses of action. Given our inability to predict how the new computer network will develop, our best chance to avoid catastrophe in the present century is to maintain democratic self-correcting mechanisms that can identify and correct mistakes as we go along.

But can liberal democracy itself survive in the twenty-first century? This question is not concerned with the fate of democracy in specific countries, where it might be threatened by unique developments and local movements. Rather, it is about the compatibility of democracy with the structure of twenty-first-century information networks. In chapter 5 we saw that democracy depends on information technology and that for most of human history large-scale democracy was simply impossible. Might the new